

Session 18: Lot Delivered from Destruction

Key Takeaways

- Lot imitates his uncle's righteous hospitality but from a compromised location. The text paints an ambivalent portrait of Lot's character.
- In their sexual violence, the men of Sodom mirror and invert the illicit union of Heaven and Earth from Genesis 6.
- The biblical authors craft this scene as a prelude to the flood theme in the melody, with Lot's house playing the role of the ark as the place of divinely provided refuge.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 19:1-3

¹ And the two messengers went to **Sodom** in the evening.

Now, Lot was sitting **in the gate** of **Sodom**,

and Lot saw

and he arose to meet them,

and he bowed face-down on the ground,

² **and he said**,

"Look, **please**, my masters,

Please **turn aside to the house of your servant**,

and **stay the night**, and wash your feet,

and rise in the morning and go your way."

And they said,

"No, because we will **stay the night** in the town center."

³ And he pressured them very much,

and **they turned aside** to him,

and they went **into his house**,

and he made them drinks and he baked bread,

and they ate.

Genesis 19:1-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Tale of Two Hosts: Avraham and Lot

The narrative begins with a scene set in clear parallel to Avraham's welcome of the angelic men in Genesis 18:1-8.

Genesis 18:1-8 Instructor's Translation

¹ And Yahweh became seen to him among the oaks of Mamre,
and he was **sitting at the entrance of the tent ...**

² and he lifted his eyes and he saw,
and look, three men standing by him,
and he saw and **he ran from the entrance of the tent to meet them**, and he bowed to the ground.

³ And he said,
"My master, please, if I have found favor in your eyes,
please don't pass on from your servant.

⁴ Let him please take a little water,
so you can wash your feet,
and recline under the tree;

⁵ that I may take a bit of bread,
so you can sustain your hearts,
then you can pass on;
for this reason you have passed by your servant!"

And they said,

"So do as you have spoken."

...

⁷ Then Avraham ran to the cattle,
and he took a calf, good and tender,
and he gave it to the young man,
and he hurried to make it.

⁸ And he took curds and milk and the calf he made,
and he gave it before them.

Now, he was standing over them, under the tree,
and they ate.

Genesis 19:1-3 Instructor's Translation

¹ And the two messengers went to Sodom in the evening.
Now, Lot was **sitting in the gate of Sodom**,
and Lot saw and **he arose to meet them**,
and **he bowed face-down on the ground**,

² and he said,

"Look, **please, my masters**, please turn aside to the house of your servant,
and stay the night, and wash your feet,
and rise in the morning and go your way."

And they said,

"No, because we will stay the night in the town center."

³ And he pressured them a lot,
and they turned aside to him,

and they went into his house,
and **he made them drinks as he baked bread,**
and they ate.

The narrator clearly wants us to compare Lot's reception of the "angels unaware" with Avraham's reception of Yahweh and these same two angels.

The majority of the links are similarities. At every point Lot imitates the behavior of his uncle: sitting at the gate, he sees, goes to meet, bows down, invites into house for lodging, food, and rest.

There is only one substantial difference between the angels' response. With Avraham, the angels quickly accept his offer and wait under the tree. With Lot, the angels play hard to get, not accepting Lot's first offer of hospitality. This actually reflects positively on Lot's character, as it shows that his hospitality is genuine and purposeful, not simply a meaningless gesture.

The narrative begins with a positive portrayal of Lot, showing how he's like his uncle, the righteous and chosen Avraham. Even though Lot made a foolish choice to live in Sodom, prioritizing the land's Eden-like qualities while ignoring the moral corruption of the city (Gen. 13:10-13), he is himself not an evil guy. His uncle's best qualities have influenced him, and so he imitates the righteous Avraham.

It is likely this analogy between Avraham and Lot that led later interpreters to the conclusion that Lot was righteous like Avraham.

2 Peter 2:7-9 *ESV*

⁷ and if he rescued **righteous Lot**, greatly **distressed by the sensual conduct of the wicked** ⁸ (for as **that righteous man** lived among them day after day, he was tormenting **his righteous soul** over their lawless deeds that he saw and heard); ⁹ then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from tests ...

But this initial similarity does not guarantee that Lot will imitate Avraham in every way, nor does it make him the chosen one. Rather, Lot will benefit from the intercession of his uncle in the previous scene, even though he displays a clear lack of trust in the divine word of the angels (Gen. 19:17-22).

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 19:4-14

Men of Sodom Gather "From Young to Old"

⁴ Before they laid down,
then **the men of the city**,
the men of Sodom,
surrounded **the house**,
from young to old,
all the people, completely.

Men of Sodom's Speech

5 And they called out to Lot
and they said to him ,

"Where are **the men** who came to you at night?
Make them go out to us,
so that **we can know** (נִדְעָה) **them** !"

Lot's Speech

6 And Lot went out to them at **the entrance** ,
and as for **the door** , **he closed it** behind him.

7 And he said ,

"Please, my brothers, **don't do this evil** (תַּרְעוּ) !
8 Look, please, I have two daughters who **have not known** (יָדְעוּ) a man,
let me please **make them go out** to you all,
and **do** to them **what is good in your eyes** .
Just **don't do** anything to these men,
because this is the reason they came into **the shelter of my beamed-roof** !"

Men of Sodom's Speech

9 And they said ,

"Get away!

And they said ,

"This one has come as an immigrant,
and he's bringing justice as a judge?!
Now **we're going to do evil** (נַרְעוּ) **to you** , more than them!"

Men of Sodom Struck "From Little to Big"

And they brought pressure against **the man** , against Lot, very much,
and they drew near, to break down **the door** .

10 And **the men** sent out their hand,
and they brought Lot in to them, into **the house** ,
and **they closed** **the door** .

11 And as for **the men** at **the entrance** of **the house** , they struck them with blindness,
from the littlest to the biggest ,
and they struggled to find **the entrance** .

12 And the men said to Lot,

"How many here are yours?

Sons-in-law or your sons or your daughters or anyone who's yours in **the city** ,
make them go out from **this place** ,

¹³ because **we are about to cause the ruin** of **this place**,
 because the outcry against them is great before the face of Yahweh,
 and **Yahweh sent us to cause its ruin**."

¹⁴ And **Lot went out** and he spoke to **his sons-in-law who had taken his daughters**,
 and he said,
 "Get up! **Go out from this place**,
 because **Yahweh is about to cause the ruin** of **the city**!"
 But in the eyes of **his sons-in-law**, he was trying to make them laugh.

Genesis 19:1-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Men of Sodom and the Generation of the Flood

The men of Sodom are depicted in curious ways that clearly compare them to the generation of the flood, which includes the depiction of Cain's city in [Genesis 4:17-26](#), the sons of *elohim* in [Genesis 6:1-4](#), and the generation of the flood in [Genesis 6:5-22](#). In this last story, the corruption of the land is contrasted with Noah, who listens to God's command and builds the ark as a place of refuge. Also remember that the story of [Genesis 6](#) was itself set on analogy with [Genesis 3-4](#), so this episode contains hyperlinks to both earlier stories.

Genesis 19:1-14	Genesis 2-4 & 6-9
Gen. 19:1-3 A human and spiritual beings rest together "in the house"	Gen. 2 Humanity rests with Elohim in the garden
The men of Sodom surround the house: • Gen. 19:4, 9 "from young (מנער) to the old" + "we will do bad (רע) to you!" • Gen. 19:5 "bring them out that we may know (ידע) them"	The generation of the flood: • Gen. 8:21 (also 6:5) is "bad (רע) from youth" (מנערו) • Gen. 4:17 "Cain knew (ידע) his wife..."
Sex between humans and spiritual beings: Gen. 19:8 The men of Sodom want to gang-rape spiritual beings, but Lot offers his daughters (בנות): "do to them what is good in your eyes" (טוב בעיניכם))"	Sex between human and spiritual beings: Gen. 6:2 The sons of Elohim see the human daughters (בנות), that they are "good" (טוב), and they take them as they choose
<i>Men of Sodom and the Generation of the Flood.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

The men of Sodom are depicted on analogy to the rebel sons of *elohim* who violated their proper assigned realm and took wives for themselves. This inappropriate linking of Heaven and Earth and their respective creatures is the primary focus of the narrative's critique.

The flood narrative and the Sodom narrative both begin and end with stories of illicit sexual encounters that violate the proper boundaries of Heaven and Earth and family relationship (This observation was made by Yair Zakovitch in *Introduction to Inner-Biblical Interpretation*, page 49).

	Flood	Sodom
Before:	Angels (בני אלהים) → Humans (בנות האדם) Males Females	Humans (אנשי סדם) → Angels (המלאכים) Males Males
After:	Son (חם) → Father (נח) Male Male	Daughters (בנות לוט) → Father (לוט) Females Male

The Men of Sodom and the Sons of Elohim. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Lot's House, the Ark, and the Coming Flood

In contrast to the corrupt men of Sodom, righteous Lot and his family are protected and safe inside the refuge of the house, which is an Eden image combined with language about the ark.

Lot, his daughters, and the angels take refuge in his house.

- The words "the house" (הבית) and "into the house" (הביתה) are the word "ark" backward (התיבה, with the י representing the long e vowel).
- The men gather at "the entrance" (פתח) of the house, by the "shut door" (הדלת סגר, [Gen. 19:6, 9-10](#)).
- "they have taken shelter under the shadow of my beam-roof" (בצל קרתי, [Gen. 19:8](#)).

Noah, his family, and the animals take refuge in the ark.

- The word "the ark" (התיבה) is the word "the house" (הבית) backwards.
- The ark is designed with an "entrance" (פתח, [Gen. 6:16](#)) in the side, that is "shut" (סגר, [Gen. 7:16](#)) behind him.
- The ark is built with a roof (צהר, [Gen. 6:16](#)).

The angels announce that a flood of judgment is coming on Sodom.

- "go out (יצא) from this place" ([Gen. 19:12](#)).
- "we are about to ruin (שחת) this place ... Yahweh has sent us to ruin (שחת) this place" ([Gen. 19:13](#)).
- "the outcry (צעקה) is great before the face of Yahweh" ([Gen. 19:13](#)).

God announces to Noah that a flood of judgment is coming.

- "go into (בוא) the ark" ([Gen. 6:18](#)).

- “the land was ruined (שחת) before the face of *Elohim*, and filled with violence” + “I about about to cause their ruin (שחת) with the land” (Gen. 6:11, 13).
- “an end of all flesh has come before my face (בא לפני) ... קץ, Gen. 6:13).

Just like with the flood, the outcry of the oppressed has risen up against the city of Sodom (Abel's blood also goes up in Gen. 4:10). The city is already in a state of ruin, so God hands the city over to destruction in the same language as the flood narrative.

However, there is an inversion: Even though Lot's “house/ark” is his refuge, he actually has to “go out” (יצא) of the ark, precisely what Noah was told to do after the flood has subsided (“go out from the ark” Gen. 8:16-19).

Reflection Question

Compare and contrast Lot's behavior in this scene with Avraham's in Genesis 18:1-16. What do the similarities and differences tell us about Lot's character?